

The Silence Between Replies



I don't think relationships usually end in one conversation.

They end in smaller moments.

A reply that takes a little longer.

A conversation that feels slightly shorter.

A laugh that doesn't quite arrive the way it used to.

Nothing dramatic.

Nothing anyone else would notice.

Just...

small absences.



At first, I blamed life.

Work.

Being tired.

Being busy.

Those were all reasonable explanations.

Life happens.

Adults have responsibilities.

I understood that.

Or at least...

I wanted to.



The strange thing about distance is that it rarely introduces itself.

It doesn't knock on the door.

It quietly moves furniture around until one day the room feels unfamiliar.

The conversations were still there.

But something had changed.

The rhythm.

The ease.

The feeling that we were both arriving in the same place at the same time.



I found myself reading messages twice.

Not because I didn't understand them.

Because I was looking for something between the lines.

Was she tired?

Was something bothering her?

Did I say something wrong?

Should I have asked differently?

Loved differently?

Given more?

Given less?

Questions became my new language.

Answers became harder to find.



I don't think I was trying to save the relationship.

Not yet.

At first...

I was only trying to understand it.

There's a difference.

One reaches outward.

The other searches inward.

I kept choosing inward.

Maybe too much.



Looking back now, I realize something about the way I love.

When I notice distance...

I don't pull away.

I step closer.

I ask more questions.

I offer more reassurance.

I become more present.

Because somewhere inside me, love has always sounded like,

"If something's wrong, let's fix it together."

I never learned that sometimes...

the other person has already started walking in a different direction.



The messages changed.

Not all at once.

Slowly enough that hope could still keep up.

A shorter reply.

A conversation ending a little earlier.

Plans becoming "maybe."

Then "we'll see."

Then nothing.

Hope is stubborn like that.

It can survive on very little.

Sometimes...

too little.



There were nights when I'd stare at the screen longer than I should have.

Not waiting for the notification.

Waiting for certainty.

There's a difference.

One arrives with a sound.

The other almost never arrives at all.



I remember typing messages...

then deleting them.

Typing again.

Deleting again.

Trying to find the exact combination of words that would somehow bring us back to where we'd been only days before.

As though love could be recovered through better punctuation.

Better timing.

Better sentences.

I know now that it doesn't work that way.

But at the time...

it felt like maybe the next message would be the one that made everything okay again.



The hardest part wasn't the silence.

It was not knowing what the silence meant.

People can survive difficult truths.

It's uncertainty that keeps them awake.

I wasn't afraid of the answer.

I was afraid of never getting one.



Today, when I reread those conversations, I no longer see someone failing.

I see someone trying.

Trying to understand.

Trying to communicate.

Trying to hold onto something that still felt worth fighting for.

There's no shame in that.

Love should never make us ashamed of having loved.



I don't blame the version of me who kept asking,

"Hon?"

or,

"Can we talk?"

He wasn't weak.

He wasn't desperate.

He was simply someone who still believed conversations could save what silence was quietly taking away.

Maybe that's naïve.

Maybe that's hopeful.

Maybe it's both.



If I could sit beside that version of myself now, I wouldn't tell him to stop loving.

I wouldn't tell him to stop hoping.

I'd only put a hand on his shoulder and whisper,

"You don't have to carry this by yourself."

Because sometimes...

the bravest thing love can do...

is accept that it takes two people to keep a conversation alive.



This wasn't the ending.

Not yet.

But if I listen carefully now...

I can hear it approaching.

Not like thunder.

Like footsteps.

Quiet enough to ignore.

Until they aren't.



— Ralph.

